PROTAGONIST GUIDE TO PERSONAL GROWTH

Satiate your ever-present desire to improve yourself and gain knowledge

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Personal Growth Matters for Protagonists

For Protagonists, personal growth isn't optional – it's a necessary and rewarding part of life. Protagonists are constantly seeking opportunities to learn, to develop, and to expand their horizons – in other words, to grow into the people they know they can be. The prospect of staying the same doesn't sound reassuring or comfortable to people with this personality type. Instead, it sounds an awful lot like stagnation.

So what motivates Protagonists' interest in personal growth? The goal isn't to show off their skills or their superiority. Protagonists find it intrinsically rewarding to build new skills and gain a deeper understanding of the inner workings of their own minds and behaviors, but they aren't just thinking of themselves. For Protagonists, self-improvement is especially valuable because it enhances their ability to uplift and be of use to the people around them.

Protagonists don't leave their path to self-improvement up to chance. Instead, they make dedicated, consistent efforts to learn and develop. In these pages, we offer a roadmap to help Protagonists assess and understand their personal growth on multiple levels, so that they can channel their energy toward the areas of their lives that need their attention.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Built on a Foundation

Personal development is supreme for Protagonists, as it is with all Diplomats. Their devotion to growth starts with themselves and then extends to those around them. As Intuitive Extraverts, both their internally based values and their outward sharing of those values transform them into their best selves. Their development, in many ways, rests on others. Navel-gazing alone is likely to bore these gregarious folks and leave them feeling unchallenged. However, they still need to attend to their inner lives if they are to grow.

This means that people with this personality type are both creative and reactive in their development. They form their convictions and look to the world to interpret what their ideals mean for their lives. While not natural sticklers for measurable results, they need to sense that what they do has a real impact beyond theory and beliefs, or their principles mean little. Although not necessarily tied to how others use what they bring to the table, Protagonists are, nonetheless, concerned with others' responses. When the creative and the reactive balance, they're likely to feel fulfilled.

Their dependence on feedback means they must pay attention to their effectiveness on some level, making Protagonists more strategic and analytical than might be assumed. They employ a kind of rationality that, on the surface, mimics those with a more pronounced Thinking trait; however, they still ground their decisions in morality and harmony, and their view of growth is likely to reflect a heartfelt need to behave altruistically. When it all works together, these types exhibit true wisdom.

Message of a Mentor

People with the Protagonist personality type are warm individuals who don't have any trouble inspiring other people or getting them to listen. They're passionate and strong-willed, and they quickly grasp the big picture, which they transform into a teachable moment whenever possible. They're on a life mission to spread whichever message appeals to them both in word and deed, and they find in that mission their impetus for growth. Whether or not they formally hold a title like "leader" or "teacher," people with this personality type experience and

foster their growth most when they find ways to share their wisdom with the world.

Their rare combination of intuition, sustained focus, and social skills means Protagonists may reach impressive heights in their chosen careers. Barack Obama, the 44th President of the United States, exhibits Protagonist traits: Many compare his style of explaining national concerns to that of a professor lecturing to students about nuances, intricacies, and shared values that require consideration. He often closes his speeches with a call to embrace an attitude or to take an action. Not every Protagonist is a professor or president, but they often find themselves mentoring others throughout their lives.

Although these types are mostly outgoing and enjoy leading from the front of the room, they can also play a subtler part when sharing their values. One Protagonist might be a soulful, charismatic friend whose insights on personal matters draw in advice-seekers. Another might manage a soup kitchen and provide casual yet inspirational counseling while ladling beef stew into the bowls of hungry clients. A Protagonist corporate middle manager working in commerce may establish a reputation by understanding that good customer service is a kind of ethical behavior.

People with this personality type can take countless paths and still express their basic temperament. But no matter how they choose to go through life, their sense of growth depends on actively imparting their values and ideals to others.

Motivation and Development

The following qualities describe components necessary to Protagonists' growth. The first three are motivational, reflective qualities, and fulfilling them fuels their efforts toward finding a more satisfying life by answering "why" questions. The final two are more tactical, proactive, more focused on "how."

Reflective Qualities

These qualities involve the motivational self-awareness that Protagonists must continue to nurture in order be happy, productive, and fulfilled:

- **Self-esteem** speaks to how much protagonists like themselves. Protagonists like themselves best when they do good for others.
- **Self-respect** speaks to Protagonists' sense of worth. They find their sense of worth in not only how they express compassion but also how they spread it and recruit others to their missions in life.
- **Self-confidence** is the source of energy that propels Protagonists forward in life. For this type, confidence comes from knowing that their actions are products of their genuine selves.

Development Strategies

These qualities speak to Protagonists' more active aspects of personal growth:

- **Self-evolution** describes the personal growth process these types engage in to fully develop their potential. It involves methods and tactics to satisfy their self-esteem, self-respect, and self-confidence needs.
- **Self-responsibility** is Protagonists' ability to take charge of their decisions and consequences without being dependent on others or accepting all that happens as fate. When they attribute their actions honestly, they can accept credit and blame with integrity, and they know what they can control and what they can't.

To meet their self-esteem, self-respect, and self-confidence needs, Protagonists must take a responsible approach to life and develop their core strengths and interests. When they meet these needs, the result, by definition, is a significant and happy life. However, if they

don't satisfy these needs, they can face overwhelming difficulty as they try to improve their self-esteem.

When Protagonists feel a lack of self-confidence, they can overcompensate with superficial behaviors that mimic real confidence, resulting in displays of bluster and pushiness – a far departure from their usual egalitarian approach. Because all the qualities discussed here are interdependent and overlap in many places, a disruption in one area easily disrupts others.

In the following sections, we will first discuss the characteristics of Protagonists in their ideal, balanced, and fully developed form. When these motivational aspects are used in a balanced way, they can help Protagonists lead fulfilling, productive, and happy lives.

Then we will describe the tendencies that emerge if these aspects become unbalanced. These represent departures from healthy, productive motivational strategies, leading to adverse effects when Protagonists are disconnected from their true selves.

Finally, we will discuss what can be done to improve balance in each of the motivational aspects and ways to address potential barriers to balance. Exercises and tips will be included to provide support, as well as concrete actions to rebalance their personal growth and development.

Self-Esteem

Protagonists who have self-esteem are simply people who like themselves. When self-esteem is healthy, they don't fear looking in the metaphorical mirror because they like what they see. People who like themselves are happier and more satisfied with their lives. They're also likely to care for themselves better and make smarter life choices. People do more for those they like and tend to treat them better. The same principle applies to liking oneself.

Balanced Self-Esteem

Standing for Good

Protagonists like themselves best when they're doing good for others, but it's much more than performing simple good deeds. These types

live in a world of ideas and visions that reflect their need to make the world a better place. For them, virtuous missions rest on an ideological base, depending on circumstances in only a secondary fashion. Their principles rule. When everything comes together and they help others according to those inner principles, Protagonists boost their positive self-regard.

People with this personality type want to be a caring, impactful force in their world, and their mental mirrors reflect something positive when they find ways to do so. Nonetheless, it would be wrong to depict Protagonists as one-dimensional – not all of them want to sacrifice everything for a cause. Some of them live quite normal lives, taking their kids to Little League, going out to dinner with friends, and enjoying other pedestrian pleasures and experiences. Some Protagonists use their altruistic impulses to change the world, and some use them to change the neighborhood.

Protagonists who balance their lives understand that there is more to their existence than their work. They have other features to like about themselves – features that complement their unselfish deeds yet extend beyond them. Sometimes inspiration comes from living well. Altruism is valuable, but life gets its meaning from many places – Protagonists who live that truth set a wholesome example for the people who look to them with admiration. These exemplary Protagonists have intimate relationships, find time for rest and restoration, and spend time alone with their thoughts occasionally. This balance makes Protagonists effortlessly likeable.

Standing with Charisma

When meeting their purpose in life is the basis of their self-esteem, Protagonists' outgoing nature and charisma play a big part. Protagonists can take rightful pride in their skillful ability to impress and persuade others. They can inspire and motivate others to follow their lead toward achieving idealistic goals. Their enthusiasm is mesmerizing, and they have no problem attracting others to their cause.

Saving the world – or at least their small corner of it – isn't a lone effort, and Protagonists are more at home gathering groups than they are motivating individuals (although they do both in ample quantities).

Competent recruiters and leaders need persuasive talents, and Protagonists are likely to see their effectiveness in swaying others as a primary way to enjoy self-esteem.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

Identities and Expectations

Some Protagonists can take ownership of beliefs, causes, issues, or projects to the point where their identity feels dependent on them. What they like about themselves may be less about their inherent qualities and more about the pursuits to which they dedicate themselves. Committed and strong-willed, they intensely invest themselves and treat their passions as callings worthy of great time and effort. If they over-identify with their undertakings, their self-assessment can hinge on matters over which they have little control. In such cases, if outside forces hinder or challenge their pursuits, it can severely affect their self-esteem, especially if the disruption feels like a failure.

Few can meet Protagonists' high expectations, including themselves at times. Some struggle to accept both their own and other people's weaknesses. They may fantasize about helping marginalized groups who are poor and oppressed but expect a lot out of everyone in the process. Inspiring and encouraging people often is easy for Protagonists, but they tend to expect a revolution overnight. They sometimes forget that their own appetite for change comes from lengthy consideration, whereas the people they're inspiring are experiencing a new possibility. The discrepancy can make Protagonists feel like failures when success takes time, leading to wounded self-esteem.

Unwanted Help

When they feel good about themselves, their good works flow naturally as they advance through their lives. However, Protagonists who depend on their deeds as fuel for self-esteem can defy their natures by pushing others to receive their help. But other people must want help before interventions can be helpful. Some Protagonists, especially those whose mental self-image isn't so positive, may try to boost their self-esteem by forcing their help on others.

The unfortunate consequence of forcing such unwanted help is that Protagonists do the opposite of what they intend. Instead of helping others find their own path to growth, happiness, or wellness, they push them onto the potentially wrong path. Although their need to feel better about themselves may blind them at first, Protagonists' characteristic insight eventually makes itself known. They may realize that they lost sight of some important personal standards, then admit that, on some level, they focused on their own needs more than on the needs of others.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

Matching Expectations to Reality

Protagonists' towering expectations can lead to constant disappointment. However, telling these idealistic types to "be realistic" or to "lower their expectations" typically fails to resonate. Putting altruistic ambitions into a more practical context may be challenging for a type that expects a lot of themselves, but it's often necessary for rebalancing their self-esteem. If every undertaking feels like a failure, it's hard to appreciate the effort. Protagonists need to recognize that sometimes their lofty visions set them up for disappointment.

Discouragement from lack of progress, as well as pushback from other people, can compound the problem for Protagonists. High expectations that aren't met can also create a need to control the uncontrollable: Rather than face the pain of more disappointment, these types may try to force success. Learning to do their best and then let go of the rest can help them break the cycle of harmfully blaming themselves when missions become stalled or never realized at all.

Here are some steps that Protagonists can take to practice letting go of things that aren't helpful or edifying:

- Find three material things to get rid of. Perhaps they haven't been used in the past year. Perhaps they're no longer useful or interesting.
- Rid yourself of the three things in a permanent way: give them away to a friend or neighbor, donate them, or dispose of them in the trash.
- After getting rid of the things, consider what it means to no longer have them.

The same concept applies to less material things, such as ideas, memories, or emotions, that might linger long after they have served their purpose. Considering how things help them – or don't – helps Protagonists know when they can move on without them. Learning to let go can be a cleansing experience that helps Protagonists on physical, mental, and spiritual levels.

Gaining a Clear Vision

Protagonists who force their help onto other people risk violating boundaries and upsetting relationships, so it's important for these types to uphold a clear vision of their direction and to follow it with integrity. For this personality type, that means helping other people on their *own* paths toward growth. Helping people restores self-esteem for Protagonists, but only when they support the autonomy of the people they help.

Fortunately, Protagonists project their expectations on others only when they lose sight of what's important to them. Part of rebalancing their self-esteem can mean sorting out the difference between their needs and the needs of others, then attending to those of others. Defining their essential intentions can help Protagonists achieve clarity in this area.

Maintaining a clear vision starts by defining core values. Core values aren't things to create – people discover them by examining what they consider important in life. The following exercise is a way that Protagonists can define their core values:

- Write a response for each of the following five prompts. Take a few minutes for each. Be as specific as possible.
    - I was most happy when...
    - I was most satisfied when...
    - I was most proud when...
    - I was most angry when...
    - If I could do anything to make the world better, I would...

- Based on your answers, write a two-sentence value statement about what is important and serves as your motivation to act in a way that impacts the world. In the statement, describe how you can live your best life.

Keeping a clear view of their purpose and mission can help Protagonists maintain their self-esteem, giving them paths that sustain their ideals and goals. A written value statement serves as a guide to help them stay in line with their basic intentions.

Self-Respect

Self-Respect is a sense of self-worth, and Protagonists create their sense of worth by exercising compassion. When Protagonists are nurturing their self-respect, they deal in interpersonal relationships that are much deeper than mere social connections – some may even say they forge spiritual links with others. When assuming their teacher or leader roles, Protagonists at their best share their compassion by inspiring people to embrace their own growth and to live better lives.

Balanced Self-Respect

Building Connections and Seeking Purpose

Protagonists need to exercise empathy to feel that they're fulfilling their purpose. These Extraverts specialize in big-picture causes that affect groups rather than individuals, but they also excel in one-on-one connections when necessary. Protagonists often work in helping or teaching professions where they can readily express their compassion and enjoy a sense of community.

Their creativity and empathy help these types put a unique, personal spin on what they share with others. Although they can build a compassionate message from straightforward facts and ideas, they're just as likely to use a compelling narrative to inspire their listeners.

For Protagonists, compassion goes beyond simply "getting the job done." When providing a solution to someone's problem, they may offer unorthodox suggestions that deeply affect the person they're helping.

These types will nudge others to greater heights to revolutionize their lives. When their compassionate acts are creative and groundbreaking undertakings rather than "just helping," Protagonists feel invigorated.

Mentoring as Compassion

Protagonists can content themselves without an official leadership label, but their combination of imagination, compassionate sociability, and ability to organize often manifests as a "take-charge" attitude. Their leadership style is inspirational, and though they're more likely to express it as a subtle influence rather than barked orders, the effect is no less compelling.

People with this personality type place tremendous value on mentoring – working closely to teach individuals gives these types a sense of value second only to their creative approach to compassion, and they intertwine compassion so tightly with leadership that they're unlikely to distinguish them as separate.

Any type can fall under the seductive allure of power. Protagonists, however, are more egalitarian than most types, and they can feel uncomfortable with too prominent a position in any hierarchy. They find peace as the head of a group only when they feel they are there to help pull others up to their level. If a position demands an authoritarian relationship to other group members, Protagonists are likely to abandon the role – or change it. Power is meaningless to them if they can't share its benefit with other people.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

Theatrical Empathy

To compensate for a flagging sense of self-respect, Protagonists can smother others by identifying too closely with their emotions and problems – and being too aggressive about offering solutions. Typically, they prefer to help others live their own lives and grow in their own unique ways. But if their own self-respect is lacking, they may see the stakes as high and apply pressure rather than provide gentle guidance, in the hope of proving themselves. Rather than lending a hand, they may take over.

Those who find themselves on this wayward path may become performers on the stage of various altruistic dramas. To puff themselves up, they might insist that their way is the only way out of a shared dilemma. They may try to solve problems with cleverness alone. For a while, they may not realize that their zeal serves their own sense of importance more than it serves the needs of other people. However, when this idea eventually catches up to them – and it likely will – they may feel like a fraud, consequently experiencing a crisis of self-regard.

The Sacrificed Leader

Protagonists' ideals can also tip them off-balance in the other direction. If they embrace their role as that of a servant, as idealistic leaders often do, they can take subservience too far. When their value and purpose need bolstering for whatever reason, they can amp up their sacrificial mindset and forget to compensate with self-care.

Healthy sacrifice as a leader doesn't mean becoming weak and exhausted. Once these types take on too much and exhaust their physical, emotional, and mental reserves, their reputation as leaders can diminish. Because signaling leadership with sacrifice can lessen their leadership capabilities, they may find that the very behavior meant to bolster their self-respect hurts it instead.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

Eye on the Prize

When self-respect becomes unbalanced, Protagonists may try to cover substance with style, causing them to become something they dislike: inauthentic. To restore self-respect, they need to return to making heartfelt contributions instead of putting on a show to prove how compassionate they are.

The first step to rebalancing can be to refocus on that which gives Protagonists their sense of value. Although their charismatic flair can be their flashiest asset, their enthusiasm, leadership, and cleverness don't define this personality type's worth – they build their self-respect through how they *use* these assets to change the world. Anchoring

themselves to their purpose, rather than their talents, helps them restore a sense of what they're all about.

This may take some time for reflection, and they may want to step out of the spotlight for a while. One way to do this may involve planning a private retreat to create a mission statement:

- Carve out a time and a place to simply be alone. Depending on circumstances, it can be hours or days.
- In writing, describe your purpose. It can be uncomplicated and declarative, and it requires little or no explanation – even a list of values, ideas, or important parts of life will do.
- Spend time doing something physical – paint a picture, do yoga, hike, go canoeing, play a musical instrument, shoot baskets, chop wood – anything that requires movement without a lot of complex thinking or decision-making. A lot of introspection happens when Protagonists *aren't* trying.
- Complete the retreat by spending up to 15 minutes writing a brief mission statement. An ideal mission statement is simple and coherent – someone else could casually read it and understand.

Because Protagonists continuously experience empathy and look for ways to help others, they may think there is no reason to codify their "mission." But such a mission statement, written down and available, may be exactly what's needed when life's storms strike. Like a lighthouse's beam cutting through the fog, a guiding statement can illumine the proper course for Protagonists.

Even Leaders Sleep

Protagonists who feel duty-bound to serve others can learn to both give and take without diminishing either activity. The obvious antidote to burnout from self-sacrifice is self-care. This means putting one's own needs first, at least temporarily. Finding time to nurture the body, mind, and soul is essential for everyone, especially those who give as much as Protagonists.

Taking time away from helping others may feel selfish or callous when there are so many needs in the world and so little time, but occasional

breaks are not selfish. In fact, self-nurturing and periods of restoration are essential to their future efforts. Such efforts elevate Protagonists' effectiveness to benefit other people, which, in turn, has a strong influence on Protagonists' self-respect.

Self-care means getting enough sleep, eating well, cultivating personal relationships, exercising, and having fun. The following exercise starts with fun and can help Protagonists rebalance their approach to self-care:

- Take a deep breath. Breathing is always a great way to start self-care.
- Think of a fun activity from your past that you haven't enjoyed recently. Avoid old hobbies that you abandoned or lost interest in. Instead, consider activities you wouldn't normally make time for, maybe something fun you've never tried before. You might consider bowling, trying karaoke, water skiing, or going to a movie.
- Set a time and date to partake in the fun activity. Plan for the best possible version of your good time: Give yourself the time and space to do things how you want. If you want, invite someone along – just remember, this is for you!
- Let the fun experience set the tone for a while afterward. Use the memory of it to lighten up when things get heavy.

Having fun is just the start, though. It's essential for Protagonists to find time for themselves, even if it means designating it on their calendars. Eating, sleeping, loving, living, and having fun contribute to a healthy lifestyle and, ultimately, a productive one.

Self-Confidence

Self-confidence is the internal impetus that gives people the emotional energy needed to move forward. When Protagonists feel self-confident, it's because of an innate certainty that assures them they're on the right side of what's genuine and true according to their standards.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Intentionally Authentic

For people with this personality type, a balanced sense of self-confidence comes from feeling connected to their true selves. They loathe anything they regard as phony and always strive to be real. Masks, lies, and insincerity offend Protagonists with an intensity that can surprise even their closest friends. A sense of sureness and conviction found within themselves, as well as rejection of dishonesty, provide the motivation they need to act confidently.

To feel confident, people with this personality type must remain true to who they are. To feel confident in their relationships, they must feel others are just as honest. This need for truthfulness goes beyond simply telling the truth all the time –Protagonists must live their truths. A profound commitment to truth lies beneath their self-reliance and their life pursuits. It affects their confidence if, for even a moment, they believe they're insincere or pretentious.

Knowing Themselves

The root of the self-confidence of Protagonists is their self-understanding. Only when they know their true selves can they behave faithfully toward themselves. These outwardly-focused individuals prefer to share their visions and beliefs with others, but self-confidence also requires introspection as its starting point. Protagonist are most confident when they give adequate attention to both the things they think and the things they do.

Protagonists may need to more deliberately follow the ancient Greek dictum to "know thyself." This takes some introspection about ethics and beliefs. Their default setting for this task may be to look to their own behaviors. However, Protagonists base their actions on deeply held principles, and they must also decide whether they're living up to those standards. By considering both their behaviors and their principles, they frame what it means to be genuine. This allows Protagonists to live in a way that reflects their true nature. The balance of internal understanding and external meaning yields the confidence to energize their intentions into accomplishments.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

Finding an Ever-Changing Self

Being genuine is a wholesome source of confidence. But if the sense of self isn't treated as a living, changing entity, it can be unstable. Protagonists set their goals around growth and are likely to experience personal changes throughout their lives. "Self," for them, isn't fixed in time and space – it isn't static. As a result, neither are the things that give them self-confidence.

When unconfident Protagonists experience variations in their own sense of self and purpose, they may hold on to the security of the old at the expense of the new. The obvious flaw is that, with growth, some part of them has changed. If they rely solely on what gave them confidence in the past, they can discover they no longer espouse the exact same standards or beliefs. They may see themselves as unintentional frauds, and their self-confidence may crumble. Only the words "I am no longer that person" can bring them closer to the truth.

Refusal to accept change on a less introspective level also comes into play. Protagonists can become overly invested in their causes, making it hard for them to change course once they commit. Not all those they lead may understand or accept inevitable changes, complicating matters even further. Because Protagonists' self-confidence comes from feeling connected to their genuine selves, feeling obliged to an obsolete "self," whether because of internal inflexibility or external resistance, can leave them feeling uncertain and drained.

Unintentionally Manipulative

On the other side of the scale, Protagonists can also suffer from an overabundance of confidence, which they may use to manipulate others. If Protagonists manipulate others, they usually do so unwittingly: empathizing with another person, understanding their concerns, coming up with a solution to their problem, and then convincing them it's the right course of action – without fully considering what the other person needs or wants. In darker, desperate moments, they can even resort to more conscious, Machiavellian persuasiveness if they feel it's justified – and extravagant self-confidence can seem to provide all the justification necessary.

Confidence becomes a problem for Protagonists when they project their visions over the facts, and because they're usually adept at communicating their ideas, their enthusiasm can be contagious. It's important that they recognize and understand their persuasive powers, then strive to use them wisely. Even the best intentions can produce unforeseen negative results when Protagonists fail to balance their self-confidence against others' best interests.

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Embracing Change

Protagonists are reasonably comfortable with change, in the sense that growth is change. But they prefer change when it's manageable and predictable – something that is the product of their goals and remains in their control. If it comes too quickly, too randomly, or if they face resistance, change can make Protagonists lose confidence. This is especially true if their definition of themselves become muddled in the process, if they feel like they've lost some sense of themselves. One of the ways to manage this is to encourage flexibility and security in the face of changes, small or large.

For Protagonists, monitoring their reactions to change can be a lifelong task, and it requires vigilance. Paying attention to their reactions is likely the most basic skill when it comes to appreciating and embracing evolution. Change is famously one of the few constants in the universe, and its abundance provides ample opportunity for observation. Because change can be unpredictable in everyday life, however, here are a variety of ways Protagonists can experiment:

- Find a piece of rejected clothing in the back of your closet. Perhaps it was a gift from an older relative or an unfashionable friend. Wear it just for one day.
- Pick something that is an elective daily habit, then change it for a week. For example, if you eat lunch at the same three restaurants repeatedly, avoid eating at any of them for a week. Find entirely new restaurants.
- For a week, drive home from work using new and different routes.

- If you have the flexibility, turn the day's schedule on its head. Take the task you usually do last and put it first, and flip the rest of the schedule in the same manner.
- Notice any reaction to these artificial adjustments. Although they may not feel as permanent or as profound as other changes, they likely will reveal the way you feel about and react to change. And they may help you train yourself to handle change.

Finding a degree of comfort in the face of change can help Protagonists maintain a sense of control – central to a balanced sense of self-confidence.

About Manipulation

Everybody uses indirect methods to influence others from time to time, and the human condition involves playing both roles. Judging the malignancy of manipulation involves judging the motivating factors, the degree, and the frequency. Protagonists who manipulate are likely to do it unconsciously and for reasons they feel are benign. However, when the frequency and intensity get out of hand, they can rebalance it only if they admit they have a capacity for exploitation. The first step is accepting that all humans indirectly sway others all the time, even values-minded Protagonists.

Once they accept that some methods they use are manipulative, they can begin to examine them and decide how to be less calculating. When people manipulate, they nudge others using indirect tactics. To counter that impulse, Protagonists can ask for what they want directly and succinctly as a habit, so others are clear about their requests and informed enough to decide whether they want to acquiesce or not. This doesn't mean that Protagonists' persuasive charms can never be useful tools, but they may prefer to avoid mind games once they're aware of their capacity to harm.

The following exercises can help Protagonists develop consciousness in this area:

- Develop a list of a minimum of five things to ask other people to do. If necessary, remember past situations when such requests were not made and use those. However, the more current and relevant the requests, the more useful they're likely to be.

- Ask a trusted friend, family member, counselor, or colleague to play the role of scorekeeper.
- Going down the list, write each request in two steps.
  - Step one: Write the request in a simple, actionable sentence of fewer than 10 words. (Count them.)
  - Step two: Write an explanation of why it needs to be done in no more than two medium-length sentences.
- Ask your activity partner to read and score the requests using the following scale.
  - If both the request and the reason were not clear and direct, and/or both were too long, give it a score of one point. (Use this score if neither part of the request met the instructions perfectly.)
  - If either the request or the reason was not clear or direct, or it was too long, give it a score of two points. (Use this score only if one-half of the process did not comply with the instructions.)
  - Give the request three points if both parts of the request complied with the instructions.
- Together, go over the reasons for the scores, and then repeat the exercise until all the requests on the list earn a score of three points.

Self-Evolution

The term "self-evolution" describes a more purposeful effort of establishing one's identity and direction. It involves tactics and strategies needed to fulfill self-esteem, self-confidence, and self-respect needs. Protagonists, like most Diplomats, not only enjoy the process of self-evolution, but also find meaning in the process itself; they see it as being as important as the results.

Balanced Self-Evolution

Constant Self-Improvement

Self-evolution goes beyond just self-improvement. It also involves Protagonists developing a deep personal understanding of themselves, as seen through their values, goals, and purposes. This reflection helps them define themselves.

However, understanding without any clear tactics for further growth amounts to navel-gazing, and people with this personality type are unlikely to find much satisfaction that way. Much of their value comes from how they interact with the world and contribute to it, and a plan ensures they do so with satisfaction. Protagonists exercising this effort strive to increase their ability to help others grow and to help society, or at least their corner of it, become a better place.

Self-Development as a Sacred Duty

Protagonists are likely to see growth and development as not only thing to aspire toward, but sacred duties. Whether they stand on secular, religious, or spiritual foundations, they typically have a missionary zeal for the matters that excite them – and those matters usually involve leading people to a better place.

For Protagonists, it's an abdication of duty to undertake their missions without the right equipment. Their most important equipment includes an understanding of what other people need as well as the ability to lead and persuade. Self-improvement and greater insight are serious and constant business for this personality type.

Unbalanced Self-Evolution

Extreme Growth

Some Protagonists find it difficult to balance all the parts of their lives because they can become almost obsessively involved with their work and side projects. Self-care, self-image, relationships, and recreation can all lose priority while they try to save the world. Protagonists may become so focused on making others' lives better that they forget to take some time to really live their own. Although much of their growth

happens through their interactions with others, they still need to experience the growth that comes from experiencing life.

Some Protagonists swing too far the other way, becoming so involved in self-improvement that they neglect other areas of their lives, such as social connections or basic work responsibilities. Spiritual, emotional, and ethical development in the pursuit of their true selves or purpose can remove them from what most would call the "real world." Even though they're unlikely to cloister themselves in some self-made hermitage, Protagonists may be so focused on their potential that they fail to engage fully in the here and now.

Satisfaction Just Out of Reach

One of the greatest barriers that Protagonists face in their self-evolution process is unevenness in how they develop. Because of their strong desire to grow into their "true selves," they may get caught up in the process of evolution, losing sight of who they already are.

As wonderful (and necessary) as self-evolution is, obsessing over growth can do as much harm as good. Tunnel vision can lead to constant dissatisfaction, and the resulting discontentment can cause Protagonists to burn out. Even the most selfless, humble, or confident individuals need the occasional reward of knowing they're gaining traction. The frustration of always striving yet never experiencing the pleasure of growth can be demoralizing and demotivating. Protagonists who never enjoy rich, satisfying moments along the way may struggle to find joy or happiness in their development.

Rebalancing Self-Evolution

Embracing Growth Responsibly

Determined Protagonists can be restless and demanding when it comes to personal growth. They like to explore everything, including the secrets of human nature, principles, and causes, even the depths of their own minds.

This focus on growth is one of the essential qualities that distinguish Protagonists from many other personality types. Mature Protagonists

understand that self-evolution is a progression, not an end itself. They take thoughtful, deliberate steps in development, and they balance their evolutionary path with a holistic approach. However, their focus isn't only on "becoming" – they occasionally allow themselves simply to "be" as well. They weigh spontaneity and serendipitous insights against broader, organized ideas that ensure a connection to the more mundane but necessary parts of life. Dreams and visions don't rule their growth, but rather combine with more practical considerations.

Improvisation in the arts is a metaphor for this mindset. When someone plays improvisational jazz, they're aware of how music works, and they know how to make it work. A jazz saxophone player composes music on the spot, but only because she knows the rules and has a vision for what the song is and where it's going. There are plotlines, themes, and moods to the music. It would be unbearable to listen to someone who didn't know music if they stood up and tried to do the same thing. Protagonists who balance their self-evolution learn to play their lives like smooth, improvisational jazz – with some skills, some dreams, some principles, some clear direction, some freedom, and some self-care, all combined.

Here are some things Protagonists can try to rebalance their self-development, through a study of improvisation:

- In the next week, spend some time experiencing some improvisation. Type "improv" or "improvisation" into streaming video services for a host of options.
- Watch some examples of improvisation in music, drama, visual art, and beyond.
- Once you've observed, seek out instructional material on improv. It doesn't matter which medium. Just spend some time appreciating the many facets of improvisation.
- Write down what you've observed about improvisational art. How can you use your findings to approach self-evolution?

Living life spontaneously yet staying rooted in principles and strategy creates a sublime balance in the purposeful lives of Protagonists. Those who find this balance are likely to be effective and find their paths to their best selves.

Enjoying Plateaus

In mountain climbing, a plateau is a place to stop, rest, and enjoy the view – to appreciate the terrain just traveled. Protagonists who find themselves driven by growth can look for plateaus in their journey through life. If satisfaction feels elusive, it may be that, in their intense wish to grow, they haven't taken time to notice that reasons for satisfaction and happiness abound. A lack of joy or even contentment can suggest the need for Protagonists to stop and evaluate their lives and accomplishments as the joyous moments they are.

Like most people, Protagonists need to feel some sense of success along the way. There is a reason humans celebrate, beyond a built-in desire to party – celebrations are a chance to stop and appreciate progress. Celebrations reinforce positive moments. Fêtes revel in past accomplishments and launch the participants into new ones. Protagonists who aren't experiencing satisfaction may simply need to find opportunities to celebrate.

Some ways this type can try to rebalance their sense of self-evolution:

- Gather family and friends to toast all accomplishment of the past 30 days. Make room to celebrate everyone, yourself included. (If no accomplishments come to mind, ask those attending for help coming up with ideas.)
- Write down three new goals to pursue. Plan an event to recognize their completion. It doesn't have to be extravagant. Just stop and recognize success.
- Look for ways to help others celebrate. Find one reason to congratulate one other person this month. Bring a box of donuts to work for the occasion, or bring home flowers or wine. Bring family and friends into the circle to raise a glass to growth. Just make sure the gesture is attached to the accomplishment.

Taking time to acknowledge accomplishments and celebrate progress is great way to reinforce self-evolution and to motivate greater attention to strategies for development. Milestones are important motivators. By not appreciating them, Protagonists deny themselves a fair assessment of their true progress.

Self-Responsibility

Self-responsibility is Protagonists' ability to take charge of their decisions and the consequences without being dependent on others or believing all that happens is fate. By honestly attributing their actions, they can take both credit and blame with integrity, as well as accept what is and isn't in their control.

Balanced Self-Responsibility

Independent Choices

Although they are collaborative by nature, Protagonists who practice balanced self-responsibility think independently. They decide their priorities and follow their interests, maintaining reasonable independence while also sustaining a healthy respect for others' wisdom and experience. This sense of independence allows them to enforce their personal boundaries without guilt – and lets them afford others the same right. They engage in self-care to avoid burnout and vulnerability, knowing that good stewardship of their own health and welfare is part of being responsible.

This plays out in their personal lives as well as in the leadership and mentoring roles they often occupy. Having a sense of personal responsibility, making decisions with authority, and being accountable are the marks of people who lead with integrity. U.S. President Truman had a sign on his desk reminding him: "The buck stops here." Protagonists, when they keep these characteristics balanced, can be comfortable prominently placing that sign in full view of others. However, this doesn't mean they encourage others to surrender their own responsibility, nor do they force others to depend on them. Helping others grow means helping them come to grips with their own duties; when Protagonists are on the right course, they're strong examples of what that means.

Proactive Approach

People with the Protagonist personality type who practice balanced self-responsibility are proactive. They know their core values and use them to achieve their personal goals. Self-responsibility goes beyond self-understanding, however. It includes carrying out plans, taking

responsibility for their results – both good and bad – and recognizing that the results impact others.

Most people don't have perfect lives or meet their goals flawlessly. Growth often emerges from trial and error, and failures often contribute to learning and development. Protagonists who act of their own accord understand their responsibilities when they do so, accept the results, and learn from their experiences, and their development vigorously benefits. The essential component is accepting responsibility for the result. Only then do they realize growth.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Perfectionists

Protagonists are passionate and show great determination when they care about something. Being responsible individuals, they may stall rather than do anything that can fail, because they would be accountable for the failure and accountable to the people affected by their decisions. Many suffer from logistical difficulties when trying to follow their passions and goals. Usually skillful at organization and highly proactive, some individuals with this personality type struggle with getting started. Protagonists' perfectionism can get in the way of progress when there are so many ways to achieve their goals or chase their passions. In their effort to take the perfect path forward, people with this personality type can become indecisive for weeks, months, years, or even a lifetime.

Procrastination stemming from perfectionism can be especially difficult for these outgoing people. As if their indecision isn't intimidating enough, they're also likely to grapple with it in the company of other people, making it a more public matter. In addition, they tend to take leadership positions, so their decisions affect not only themselves, but also those they lead. If they suffer from any insecurity, they may futilely search for a perfect solution. Unfortunately, life doesn't often hand those out – there are rarely perfect solutions, only better ones.

Practical Responsibility

Ethics and moral courage are driving forces in the lives of Protagonists, and they tend to handle these areas of responsibility well. But big ideas

alone don't meet goals. If people with this personality type fail to attend to details, their high-minded intentions will remain mere notions, or worse; inspiring people to undertake an arduous journey without a source of bread and water is irresponsible.

Protagonists dislike dealing with the mundane aspects that go along with achieving long-term goals. If they don't make sure that their minds stay on track, particularly during relatively dull phases, they can experience a two-fold problem. First, mundane but necessary tasks may go undone, leaving loose ends that must be tied up later (or can derail the goal completely). Secondly, Protagonists' strong sense of duty to others means they're likely to suffer guilt for neglecting important details. Self-responsibility requires taking responsibility for every aspect of life, and focus ensures they don't overlook day-to-day details.

Goal-oriented and idealistic, people with this personality type often direct all their attention to the goal, missing small yet important details in the process. It's hard to argue that someone is acting responsibly when that happens. Sometimes a great and noble project can fail because someone forgot to check the legal details, handle administrative tasks, estimate the workload, or even account for the fact that key participants didn't share the vision.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Embracing Imperfection

One of this personality type's biggest challenges is learning how to consider all aspects of a situation without letting infatuation with idealism cloud their judgment. Their tactical preference for Judging pushes Protagonists to commit sooner rather than later, but learning how to exercise control over their ideas can help keep these types from stretching themselves too thin.

Nobody makes the right decision all the time or acts in a consistently perfect manner. Protagonists, with all their insight, aren't infallible. If they're to embrace their responsibilities, they also need to embrace their imperfections. Waiting for a guaranteed perfect outcome is likely to lead to paralysis more than action – and taking responsibility often

means acting. Fortunately, these types are unlikely to act rashly when making decisions that affect others or themselves.

For those who bring themselves to accept the imperfections of their own lives, procrastination isn't likely to be a major stumbling block. Once they come to terms with the fact that no decision or action can be perfect, then give themselves permission to be responsibly flawed, they can lower their expectations to a reasonable level. Doing their best and accepting their part in the outcome cover any duty they have in most situations.

The following exercise can help Protagonists take the first small step toward this acceptance:

- Choose an activity that is challenging but not overwhelming. It might be participating in a sport, trying an artistic activity, or doing a small home repair – anything moderately considered a challenge. (Make sure to pay attention to all safety issues, and keep in mind that a good challenge is one that is difficult but not impossible.)
- Engage in the activity knowing that "good enough" is sometimes good enough.
- When finished, assess the activity. Was it perfect? Even if it wasn't, was it a worthy effort? Celebrate the flaws with a good laugh.
- Afterward, contemplate: What does this exercise reveal about being perfect?

On the surface, being perfect may sound like the most responsible path. However, in practical terms, it can lead to paralysis and indecision, so it may be the least responsible thing Protagonists can do.

Improving Focus

It doesn't matter how high-minded the ideals – if the nuts and bolts aren't tight enough, the whole machine may fall apart, and that's hardly a responsible approach. Learning to keep focus and muddle through the details, especially with long-term goals and projects, reflects a responsible attitude.

For Protagonists, the trick for remaining focused, oddly, is to set aside plenty of time every day for their mind to wander. Setting breaks for a walk or meditation, for example, makes longer periods of focus easier to achieve. Bringing themselves into the here and now can improve their attention to detail and help them regulate their obsessive attention to their higher passions. Knowing when to take a break and when to focus is integral to responsible Protagonist behavior.

Embracing this personality type's natural tendency to strategize and make plans can be useful. But relaxing their attention on "big-picture" considerations for a while can allow the smaller details to emerge from the background and take a more prominent position in the forefront. The following exercise can help Protagonists move between the big picture and the details while giving adequate attention to both:

- Find the most beautiful object available in the vicinity.
- Take a plain piece of paper and a pencil – a regular pencil is fine, but a colored pencil may make the exercise more interesting.
- With an eye toward getting as close to photo accuracy as possible, draw the object. This isn't about talent. Nonetheless, doing the best work possible in this exercise means being as accurate as possible.
- Should the mind drift toward more symbolic or abstract considerations, return to thoughts of lines, shadows, and colors. Be a camera more than an artist. Let the smaller details emerge.
- Post the picture somewhere public or private as reminder to view the small-scale details rather than only focusing on objects in a large-scale manner.

It's fine to have lofty goals designed to address noble issues. But unless Protagonists consider the details, it may all come to nothing. Like the old saying, sometimes they "can't see the trees for the forest." Responsibility demands that people with this personality type balance attention to the individual trees as well as the forest they form.

Final Words

Growing So Others Might Grow

The world needs Protagonists to grow so that they can use their insights and nurturing leadership to encourage growth in others. With their combination of traits, Protagonists can fill a variety of mentoring niches, and society would be poorer without their contributions. But their own personal growth is essential to their effectiveness. Fortunately, it's also something they highly desire for themselves.

Protagonists who leverage their strengths while expanding their comfort zones find growth by balancing integrity within themselves with adaptation toward the world around them. Understanding who they are and acting in ways that honor their values create fulfillment and a life of purpose for people with this personality type.

All Protagonists have their own spin on life, having adapted to their unique circumstances in many ways. Some skillfully navigate the process of personal growth most of the time; others, some of the time; and still others may struggle. Like all people, they fluctuate between days filled with wonderful growth and other days that lack, or even seem to undo, that growth. No one goes through life in a perfect way. Nonetheless, growth and learning are always choices for those who are willing. Hopefully, these pages have provided Protagonists with some guidance and inspiration to bolster that willingness.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you direct your personal growth journey? Explore our Personal Growth Tools and Assessments.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Protagonist Guide to Careers*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your romantic relationships, friendships, or relationships with your children? Our *Protagonist Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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